Behavioural Psychology

Individual Reflective Assignments — Course: 21GNH401TA

Course:	21GNH401TA Behavioral Psychology
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Assignment 1: Understanding Yourself for Effectiveness

Based on Unit 1 – Understanding Self for Effectiveness

Q1. Positive vs. Negative Self-Concept

Positive statements: I am determined when I set a goal. I am a loyal friend. I am curious about how systems and technology work. I am honest, even when it costs me. I am someone others can rely on in a crisis. I am open to changing my mind with new evidence. I am creative in finding solutions to practical problems. I am improving every semester. I am capable of deep focus when motivated. I am a person who keeps his word.

Negative statements: I am not disciplined enough about routines. I am too hard on myself when I make mistakes. I am sometimes too stubborn to ask for help.

Reflection: The positive statements came more easily than I expected, but I noticed I was cautious — almost hedging each one. The negative statements felt more immediately 'true' even though they are fewer. This tells me that my self-critical voice may carry more weight per statement than my affirming one, which is something I want to actively work on.

Q2. Self-Concept Circle

Body: I am reasonably fit and I take my physical health seriously through regular exercise. However, I tend to neglect rest and push myself even when my body clearly needs a break. Personality: I see myself as direct, analytical, and sometimes impatient when things move slower than they need to. I am more comfortable with logic than with emotional ambiguity. Abilities: I am strong in technical subjects and problem-solving. My verbal communication in formal settings is an area I am actively trying to improve. Role in family: I am the only son, and there is an unspoken expectation that I will be the primary support for my parents as they age. I carry this seriously, though it sometimes adds to my pressure. Hardest section: The 'Body' section was hardest because writing honestly about how I treat my own physical wellbeing forced me to acknowledge habits I prefer to ignore.

Q3. Twenty Statements Test — Who Am I?

Based on Self-Concept

1. I am an engineering student. (Social)
2. I am a son and sibling. (Social)
3. I am someone who thinks too much before acting. (Psychological)
4. I am 5 feet 10 inches tall. (Physical)
5. I am a person who values logic above emotion in decisions. (Psychological)
6. I am someone who struggles to switch off at night. (Psychological)
7. I am a team member who carries more than my share. (Social)

8. I am physically stronger than I look. (Physical)
9. I am afraid of mediocrity. (Psychological)
10. I am still learning to trust people easily. (Psychological)

Reflection: Psychological statements form the largest part of my list (5 of 10), followed by Social (3), Physical (2). This suggests that I currently understand myself mainly through my inner qualities, thoughts, and values, while the other parts also contribute to my identity.

Q4. The Wheel of Emotions

During the inter-college hackathon last semester, in the final hour before our presentation, I experienced one of the most complex emotional states I can remember. The five core emotions were: excitement (the product actually worked the way we designed it), fear (of losing after weeks of preparation), pride (in the team and what we had built), frustration (a minor glitch appeared twenty minutes before we went on), and determination (a decision-like feeling that failure was simply not acceptable right now). The trigger was the specific combination of high stakes, real uncertainty, and the fact that people I respected were watching.

Q5. The Feeling Wheel — Naming My Emotions

During a lab practical three weeks ago, I experienced an emotion I would describe as humiliated. My circuit design had an error that the demonstrator pointed out in front of the entire bench row. It was not done unkindly, but I felt the eyes of my peers and my face went hot. What triggered it was not the correction itself — I know errors are part of learning — but the public nature of it in a space where I had been trying to establish credibility. I responded by going very quiet and focused for the rest of the session, which helped me finish correctly, but I did not fully process the feeling until much later that evening.

Q6. Reframing a Challenge Optimistically

Initial feeling: My application for a competitive summer internship was rejected after I had progressed to the final round. My first reaction was: 'I am clearly not as good as I thought. If I cannot get this, I am not cut out for a competitive career.' I felt genuinely deflated for several days.

Reframed version: I made it to the final round of a highly competitive process — that is not failure, that is evidence of real capability. The outcome was likely determined by factors specific to this round and this cohort, not by a fixed limit in me. I now have a clear picture of the gap between where I am and where I need to be, which is actually valuable information.

What changed: Reframing moved the rejection from being about my permanent worth to being about a specific moment in a process I am still inside. That made it possible to plan next steps instead of withdrawing.

Q7. My Optimism Test Result

My Psychology Today Optimism Test result placed me in the 'realistic optimist' category — slightly above the midpoint but not in the high range. I think this is accurate. I am not naturally an 'everything will work out' thinker; I tend to plan for what could go wrong. But I also do not give up easily once I have committed to something. My moderate optimism probably means I do better with structured challenges where effort has a clear link to outcome, and that I struggle more with uncertain or ambiguous situations where the work-to-reward relationship is unclear.

Q8. Why Self-Awareness Matters to Me

Self-awareness matters to me because I am someone who defaults to action and can easily miss signals from my own body and mind when I am in motion. Without deliberate reflection, I would keep running on autopilot and not notice the costs until something broke. One real example: During my second

semester I was pushing through a heavy workload without sleep and attributing my increasing irritability to other people being annoying. It took a direct comment from a close friend — 'you have been impossible to be around this week' — to make me stop and realise I was running on empty. That moment of self-awareness led me to sleep for ten hours and completely reset. The 'other people' had not changed; I had, and I had not noticed.

Q9. My Johari Window

Open: I am competitive and I do not hide it. My friends and classmates know this, and I know it about myself. It drives me in useful ways but can also make collaboration more tense than it needs to be.

Hidden: I carry a constant quiet anxiety that I am not working hard enough or smartly enough to meet the expectations of people I respect — particularly my parents. I rarely show this, as I want to appear composed and capable.

Blind Spot: A teammate once told me that when I get absorbed in a technical problem, I become completely unapproachable — I do not respond to questions, I seem irritated, and people stop bringing issues to me. I had no idea I was doing this, and it had been affecting the team's communication without my awareness.

Q10. My Self-Esteem Tree

Roots: My father's example of quiet consistency; the value of problem-solving I developed early; the belief that preparation and effort matter more than talent.

Trunk: Analytical thinking, reliability under pressure, and deep focus.

Branches: Engineering student, son, friend, junior team lead in the college technical club.

Leaves: Leading the team to the hackathon finals; completing a self-initiated coding project over winter break; helping a struggling classmate understand a module over three sessions.

Fruits: Building something that solves a real problem for real people; being someone the next generation of students in my club looks up to the way I looked up to mine.

Reflection: I am proudest of the Leaves — specifically the moments that were entirely self-initiated, without any external push. They are evidence that my motivation can come from within, not just from deadlines or expectation, which is something I want to build more of.

Assignment 2: Thinking, Problem-Solving & Life Skills

Based on Unit 2 (Problem Solving & Creativity) and Unit 3 (Life Skills)

Q1. Opening My Mind

If humans could only communicate through images, the first casualty for me would be precision. So much of what I study — engineering, logic, structured argumentation — depends on exact language. Replacing that with images would force me to think in systems and relationships rather than definitions. Friendships would become more intuitive and less analytical. Family conversations, which often rely on a lot of implied verbal context, would have to become more literal and visual. What this exercise revealed is that I think primarily in sequences and categories — my mind organises through language first and imagery second. Removing language would genuinely reshape how I process experience, and not entirely for the worse.

Q2. Thinking About My Thinking

1. Whether the code I wrote last night will cause a problem during today's lab — future / task.
2. A conversation I had yesterday that did not go the way I intended — past / someone else.
3. Whether I am spending enough time on subjects that matter for my career — future / myself.
4. How the system I designed for the club project could be more efficient — task / present.
5. Whether my parents are doing alright without me around — others / present.

Pattern: My thinking is predominantly forward-facing and task-oriented, with a secondary thread of concern for the people I care about. I rarely think about the past unless something unresolved is pulling at me. This probably makes me efficient but also means I process difficult experiences less than I should.

Q3. Fast vs. Slow Thinking in My Life

Fast thinking decisions: (1) Switching the approach on a coding problem mid-session without stopping to plan. (2) Agreeing to take on the role of team lead without fully considering the time commitment. (3) Ordering the same meal at the canteen without thinking because it is reliable and fast.

Slow thinking decisions: (1) Deciding which programming language to learn this semester based on job market trends, project goals, and learning curve. (2) Figuring out how to address a persistent conflict within my project team through structured conversation rather than avoidance. (3) Planning how to structure my final semester to leave time for applications and interviews. The slow thinking decisions consistently produced better outcomes. The fast thinking decision to agree to team lead without thinking it through led to a schedule collision that cost me two weeks of academic focus. Speed has its place, but most things that matter deserve more than an instant response.

Q4. Reverse Thinking — Flip It Around

To become the worst listener in class, I would:

1. Keep my laptop open and switch tabs whenever I lost interest → Flip: Close all non-class applications during lectures.
2. Mentally formulate my response before the speaker finishes → Flip: Wait until the speaker has fully finished before forming a response.
3. Assume I already know what is being said and stop paying attention → Flip: Approach every session as if I might hear something I do not yet know.
4. Sit near the back where I feel less observed → Flip: Sit where I am engaged and visible, which keeps me accountable.

5. Never ask a follow-up question → Flip: Prepare at least one genuine question before each class.

6. Treat listening as passive receiving → Flip: Treat listening as active reconstruction — building the idea as it is spoken. Habit I will practise this month: waiting until the speaker finishes before responding. Identify an unhelpful habit Flip it into a positive action Practise the action regularly Review and adjust progress Fig. 2.1: Reverse-thinking process

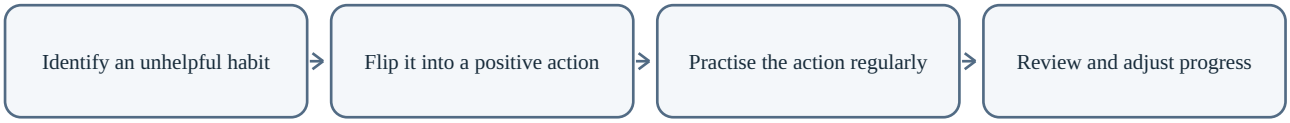


Fig. 2.1: Reverse-thinking process

Q5. My Personal SWOT

Area chosen: Time Management

Strengths: I can sustain long focused work sessions without distraction; I meet deadlines reliably; I am good at identifying the most important task when I have multiple competing demands.

Weaknesses: I tend to underestimate how long tasks take, which creates back-loading; I resist breaking large tasks into smaller steps because I find task-switching frustrating; I do not allocate buffer time for unexpected problems.

Opportunities: My college offers time management workshops; using project management tools I already know professionally but rarely apply to academic work; having a study partner who approaches time differently and could balance me.

Threats: My tendency to take on additional responsibilities beyond my capacity; social media during transition periods between tasks; physical fatigue from irregular sleep patterns compressing my effective working hours.

Q6. Active Listening in Practice

I asked my roommate to speak for two minutes about his day. He talked about a disagreement he had with a lab partner who had not completed their section of the work, the frustration of having to cover for someone else, and his uncertainty about whether to raise it formally or just absorb the extra work this once. By the end, he seemed less agitated just from having been heard.

Reflection: The hardest part was not problem-solving. When he described his situation, my mind immediately went to 'here is what you should do.' I had to consciously keep myself from jumping in with solutions he had not asked for. This made me realise how often I frame listening as information-gathering in preparation for advising, rather than as a full act in itself.

Q7. The Floor Is Yours

Prompt chosen: (b) My own life goal, explained to someone who has never met me. "I want to build infrastructure — not just code or systems, but the kind of underlying architecture that other people build their work on top of without knowing it is there. The way a road lets a city function without everyone having to think about civil engineering every time they drive somewhere. I am drawn to backend systems, to the invisible logic that makes everything else possible. I am not particularly motivated by being recognised — I find it more satisfying to build something that works so reliably people stop noticing it. If the most honest version of success I can describe is a system I built running quietly in the background of something important, that is enough for me. I am here to become someone who can build that. Everything else right now is preparation."

Q8. Stepping Into Empathy

During a college trip in my first year, we passed through a village where I saw a small boy sitting alone on the steps of a shuttered school. He could not have been more than eight years old, and he had a textbook open on his lap, though there was no sign of anyone around him. I watched him for about a minute without him noticing me. Something about the image — the seriousness of a child studying alone in a place that looked like it had been forgotten — moved something in me that I did not expect. I did not go over to him; I do not know what I would have said. But I found myself thinking about that image for weeks afterward. It changed how I approach the idea of access to education. It made something abstract into something that had a face, and I have not been entirely the same about it since.

Q9. Treating Others Respectfully

Based on Respect

1. My father: I show respect by valuing his advice, keeping my commitments, and making an effort to act responsibly. I know that being dependable is an important way to acknowledge his support.

2. My mother: I show respect by staying in touch, listening to her concerns, and not taking the care she gives me for granted. I can improve by being more present during calls instead of letting work distract me.

3. My teacher: I show respect by preparing before class, listening carefully, submitting work responsibly, and asking focused questions rather than interrupting.

Honest evaluation: I make a conscious effort to respect all three. I am most consistent with my teachers in academic settings, while I want to be more regular and attentive in my conversations with my parents.

Q10. Building It Back Up — Resilience

In my second year, I spent two months designing a software module for the college technical fest project. It was the most ambitious thing I had attempted, and I had quietly told myself it would be the centrepiece of the team's submission. Three days before the fest, we discovered a fundamental compatibility issue — my module could not integrate with the existing system without a complete rewrite that we did not have time for. The team made the right decision to drop it and simplify the submission. I did not handle the first hour well. I was quiet in a way that communicated anger, and I know the team felt it. But by the following morning something had shifted. I looked at what remained, identified where I could genuinely contribute in the time left, and focused there entirely. The simplified version still won recognition in its category. What I learned is that resilience for me is not about pretending the collapse did not hurt. It is about the lag time — how quickly I can get from the floor back to forward motion. I am still working on shortening that lag, but I know it is shorter than it used to be.

Assignment 3: Stress, Personality & Socialization

Based on Unit 4 (Stress & Coping) and Unit 5 (Personality, Socialization & Human Values)

Q1. Sorting My Stress

Controllable Uncontrollable

1. Backlog of unreviewed lecture notes
1. Uncertainty around campus placement timelines
2. Unfinished personal coding project I keep deferring
2. A team member's repeated failure to deliver their section on time
3. Irregular meal and sleep schedule
3. Rising family expectations tied to my academic performance What struck me doing this exercise was how much energy I had been directing toward the uncontrollable column — specifically the placement uncertainty and the team member situation. Neither of those is within my control right now. Identifying that explicitly has helped me redirect at least some of that energy back to the controllable column.

Q2. Recognising My Own Stress Symptoms

Physical: When I am significantly stressed, I develop a dull tension headache that sits behind my eyes. It tends to build through the afternoon if I have been in front of a screen without proper breaks.

Emotional: I become detached — not sad or anxious in an obvious way, but I stop feeling engaged with things I normally enjoy, like new technical problems or conversations with friends. Everything starts to feel like obligation.

Cognitive: I begin making small but unusual errors — typos in code I would normally catch immediately, misreading instructions, forgetting simple things. My working memory feels compressed.

Behavioural: I delay starting anything new and spend excessive time reorganising and 'preparing to prepare,' which is a form of productive-looking avoidance.

Q3. The 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding Exercise

5 things I can see: My monitor's idle screen, a half-full glass of water, a stack of printed notes, the window showing an overcast sky, and a pen on the edge of my desk. 4 things I can touch: The smooth hard surface of my desk, the textured grip of my chair's armrest, the flat cool glass of water, the edge of a notebook slightly worn from use. 3 things I can hear: The cycling noise of the ceiling fan, distant traffic, and someone playing music at a low volume two rooms away. 2 things I can smell: The faint metallic smell of the room and the mild detergent from my shirt. 1 thing I can taste: Water from the glass I just drank.

Reflection: The exercise worked more effectively than I expected for something so simple. By the fourth item in each category, I noticed my shoulders had dropped and my breathing had slowed. It did not resolve anything but it did interrupt the anxiety loop long enough for me to feel present again.

Q4. Nature Journaling

I sat in the small garden area behind the college library for ten minutes in the early morning before classes. The light was low and the air still had a coolness to it. I watched a spider completing the final adjustments to a web between two low shrubs, working with what seemed like total commitment to something most people would not notice. The sky had thin streaks of cloud and the birds were louder than usual. I am not naturally drawn to nature reflection — I tend to find it abstract as a concept. But those ten minutes felt unusually still. The spider particularly stayed with me: something building carefully and precisely in the early hours before anyone else arrived. I did not feel less stressed, exactly,

but I felt less hurried, which may be its own kind of relief.

Q5. My Go-To Coping Strategy

My primary coping strategy is structured problem decomposition — when I am overwhelmed, I sit down and break whatever is causing the stress into its smallest components, list them, and address them one at a time. It works well for academic and technical stress, which makes up most of mine. I am honest, though, that this strategy fails for the kinds of stress that are not decomposable — family pressure, interpersonal tension, uncertainty about the future. For those, I do not yet have an equally effective strategy. I tend to default to work as distraction, which provides temporary relief but does not actually process the underlying feeling. I know this is an area I need to develop. Notice stress signals Pause and identify the cause Choose a healthy coping action Reflect, recover and reset Fig. 3.1: Healthy coping sequence

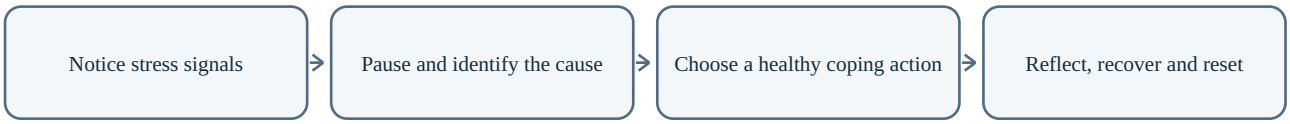


Fig. 3.1: Healthy coping sequence

Q6. My Big Five Personality Profile

My scores from bigfive-test.com were approximately: Openness: 69 | Conscientiousness: 76 | Extraversion: 35 | Agreeableness: 55 | Neuroticism: 48 The high Conscientiousness fits — I am structured, goal-oriented, and take my commitments seriously, sometimes to the point of rigidity. The low Extraversion is accurate; I work well alone and find sustained social interaction draining. The moderate Agreeableness reflects a tension I actually feel: I value cooperation but I am also direct enough that I will push back when I think something is wrong. The moderate Neuroticism was reassuring — I had expected it to be higher. The Openness score slightly surprised me; I would have placed it higher, though I recognise I am more open to technical novelty than to social or artistic ambiguity.

Q7. My Personality Type in Action

The trait I identify with most strongly is high Conscientiousness. A specific example: during the semester when our team was given an open-ended project brief with no defined deliverables, most members were comfortable working loosely toward a vague direction. I could not function that way. Within the first meeting, I had drafted a project specification document with milestones, deliverables, and a timeline, and circulated it to the group. The team found it helpful, though one member later told me it had also felt slightly constraining — that my instinct to structure everything had narrowed the creative space before it had been fully explored. I found that feedback genuinely useful and something I still think about.

Q8. Learning the Unwritten Rules

When I joined the technical club in my second semester, I assumed the culture would be purely meritocratic — the best idea wins, full stop. I discovered quickly that there was a strong unwritten norm around how ideas were introduced. Presenting a new approach as 'this is better than what we are doing' was met with resistance, regardless of how correct it was. The same idea framed as a question — 'I was wondering if there might be a way to try this differently' — received an entirely different response. I adapted by learning to frame contributions as invitations rather than corrections. I stayed true to myself by continuing to push for what I believed was technically correct — just through a different door. I do not think I compromised my values; I adjusted my delivery.

Q9. A Different Perspective

My closest friend in college, Arjun, grew up in a family that had moved across three states before he was sixteen — his father's work required frequent relocation. He has a completely different relationship with belonging than I do. Where I see home as a fixed, anchoring concept, Arjun treats it as portable — something he carries with him rather than returns to. What I learned from him was that my attachment to staying in familiar environments is partly comfort and partly avoidance. His ease with the unfamiliar is not just a personality difference — it is a skill built through repeated practice. That realisation changed how I think about my own resistance to change, and I have been deliberately choosing unfamiliar situations more often since we had that conversation.

Q10. My Code of Ethics

During a placement preparation session in my third year, our group was sharing resources for a commonly used aptitude platform. One member shared a file that contained what were clearly leaked internal question papers — not preparation material, but actual future test content. Several people in the group began studying from it immediately, calling it 'strategy.' I did not use the file. I also did not report it, which is a decision I have continued to examine. What I did do was tell the person who shared it directly that I was not comfortable with it and would not use it, and that I thought it was a risk they were underestimating — both ethically and practically. The value that guided me was fairness. It was not about following a rule; it was about knowing that using leaked material would mean my result was not actually mine. Even if no one ever knew, I would know. And a performance that is not genuinely mine tells me nothing useful about where I actually stand. Yes, I would make the same choice again.